various museums. Instead, they built a Parthenon of words: the Sanskrit language, since *saṃ skṛta* means ‘perfect’.[15]

The Arya’s everyday spoken language was an early form of Prakrit, meaning ‘original’ or ‘vernacular’, out of which there emerged the more refined, hieratic and priestly Sanskrit, the language of the *Vedas*. These *Vedas* were originally spoken of as *shruti*, or ‘that which is heard’, composed to be chanted as hymns. They consisted of four collections in total, assembled over the course of some thousand years from about 1500 BCE onwards. They were too sacred to be sung by anyone other than the priests, so they were committed to memory and passed on by oral transmission within the priestly community. Only many centuries later were they set down in writing as the first of the sacred texts of what we now call Hinduism – unless, of course, you believe that the language these Arya spoke was first written in the pictographic characters of the civilisation they replaced, in which case you have to account for the gap of more than a thousand years between the last Harappan pictographs being made and the first appearance of Brahmi script in the third century BCE.

The *Vedas* chart the eastward progress of a people made up of five tribes who were never overwhelming in terms of numbers but whose better organisation and more advanced technology – characterised in the horse and the chariot – gave them the edge, leading to their assuming authority over the host population. The history of India is replete with similar but better documented examples, from Alexander the Great and his highly disciplined Macedonian troops in the fourth century BCE to Major Stringer Lawrence’s creation of a modern Indian army based on the Prussian model in Madrasapatnam in the 1750s.

The earliest and most important of the four works that make up the *Vedas* is the *Rig-Veda* (*R-V*), which can be